

War on MEMORY

Lest you remember life's lacerations in India's poster city of progress and promise



LESSONS IN FORGETTING
by ANITA NAIR
HarperCollins India
Price: Rs 399
Pages: 344

| By Brinda Bose |

"I can handle him, she thinks. When in doubt, a stew. But when lightness lifts your soul, time to whip up a batch of meringues."

Anita Nair can handle it—a grim tale of a luminous, mercurial young girl shattered into a whimpering, cowering animal both by a stray log that comes crashing from the sea and the viciousness of men dealing in the illegal business of snuffing out female foetuses; a sorry story of a frothy corporate marriage that disintegrates like a delicate wine-glass knocked over by a careless bejewelled hand at a cocktail party; a touching chronicle of four generations of women in a family negotiating disparate yet entwined lives; a fragile vision of two lost souls swimming in a fish bowl, until they shore up against the promise of possible redemption in each other—all of it, with the expert flair of a chef extraordinaire

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whipping up featherweight meringues to match the lightness and delicate sweetness of souls. Nair's latest, *Lessons in Forgetting*, is like an experience in fine dining—it tantalises your palate and makes you want to chew slowly upon its offerings, and it makes you want to linger at the table just a little while longer.

What is it that we are meant to learn to forget then, like obedient students in a classroom called life? Nair, in a profound exploration of human love and suffering, offers us a philosophy of forgetting as a survival trick: in Pink Floydian terms, she suggests that we must learn to distinguish blue skies from pain, to retrieve what might sustain us from the plethora of that which continually threatens to crush our spirits and break us, leaving us scattered like dried and twisted twigs amongst the sand-dunes after the sea has retreated. This is an image that is impaled upon our consciousness as a central motif in the novel, the searing, seething form of a vivacious and intrepid young NRI woman Smriti—who returns to India with her parents to connect with her roots and is destroyed when she begins to look too closely at the ills of her homeland—lying curled and writhing upon her bed in a monstrous battle with living and forgetting. Smriti, exemplifying the irony of her name, is endlessly locked in a combat with memory, making grotesque faces and emitting grunts and growls like a wild animal in pain as her father, the renowned Professor J.A. Krishnamurthy (a.k.a. "Cyclone Jak" for his eminent scientific research on stormy weather patterns) watches over her in despair and devotion and dedicates his days to searching for the elusive truth behind the "freak accident" at a seaside town which found his radiant, ebullient daughter ensnared and sucked into a vortex of torment for the rest of her living years.

And how does one forget life's repeated lacerations, whether they are physically experienced and manifest as Smriti's are, resulting in a body and mind equally mutilated and contorted, or simply endured, as Meera's are? Meera's story is the counterpoint to Jak's in Nair's simple interweaving of lives and longings in contemporary Bangalore, the poster-city of progress and promise in post-liberalisation India. Nair's skills